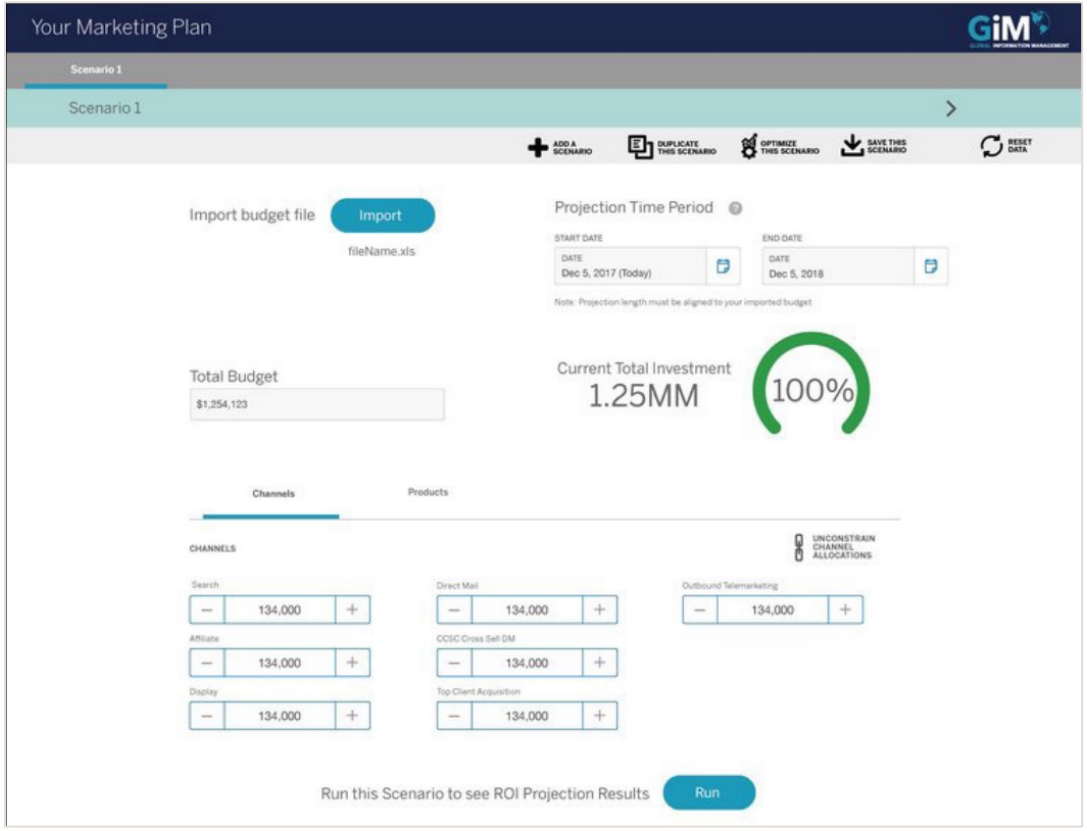
AMEX MOCA

Budget planning that partners trust enough to grow



"Comparing budgets and then optimizing it would allow me to have the confidence to increase the budget."

AMEX sales partner, discovery interview

Lead UX designer

Discovery, strategy and hands-on design; co-design with data scientists; Sketch, Lean UX, usability testing; presented to client stakeholders.

At a glance

The problem	AMEX sales partners had no tool to help clients budget their advertising spend, compare scenarios, or see what each dollar would do.
The target	Raise partner approval (58% baseline), cut budget drop-off (5.4%) and time to build a budget (12 min), and grow average client budgets ($1.34M).
The decision I made	Turn budgeting into a 3-step flow: a guided wizard, a scenario builder down to channel and product, and a side-by-side comparison with an optimized plan the partner chooses.
What we gave up	One quick, single-plan form. Building and comparing scenarios adds a step (about 5 min of comparison) in exchange for confidence. (confirm)
The result	Partner approval 58% → 88%. Drop-off 5.4% → 3.4%. Time to build a budget 12 → 10 min. Average client budget $1.34M → $1.8M.
My role	Lead UX designer: discovery, strategy and hands-on design, working with data scientists over 12 Agile sprints. Team size (confirm).

What changed after launch

Measured against the baseline we set in discovery. (confirm the measurement period)

Partner approval

58% → 88%

+30 pts

Budget drop-off

5.4% → 3.4%

–2.0 pts

Time to build a budget

12 min → 10 min

–2 min

Average client budget

$1.34M → $1.8M

+34%

New capability: partners spend about 5 minutes comparing scenarios, a step that did not exist before.

The product, the people, the constraints

What MOCA is

A desktop budgeting application that uses algorithmic engines to project a marketer's potential budget, and to compare constructed and optimized budget scenarios.

Who uses it

AMEX sales managers and sales advisors, building advertising budgets with their external clients across AMEX product lines and channels.

Used rarely

Partners build a plan every 6–12 months, so every visit feels like the first.

High stakes

Average client budget of $1.34M at baseline; partners had to defend each allocation.

A desktop app among others

It had to sit beside other desktop tools and connect to them through APIs.

What partners told us

How we learned

Interviews with stakeholders, SMEs and users (sales managers and advisors)

Contextual interviews

Personas

Co-design sessions with data scientists

"If I could build a plan down to the product line and channel, I'd be super happy, but I'd also be able to customize each quarter."

Sales partner

What we learned

Partners want to compare budget scenarios, not fill in one plan

They need to see, in a chart, how effective each scenario is

They want to adjust each channel, and each product inside a channel

Short term vs long term matters to every decision

Because they plan only every 6–12 months, they need guidance

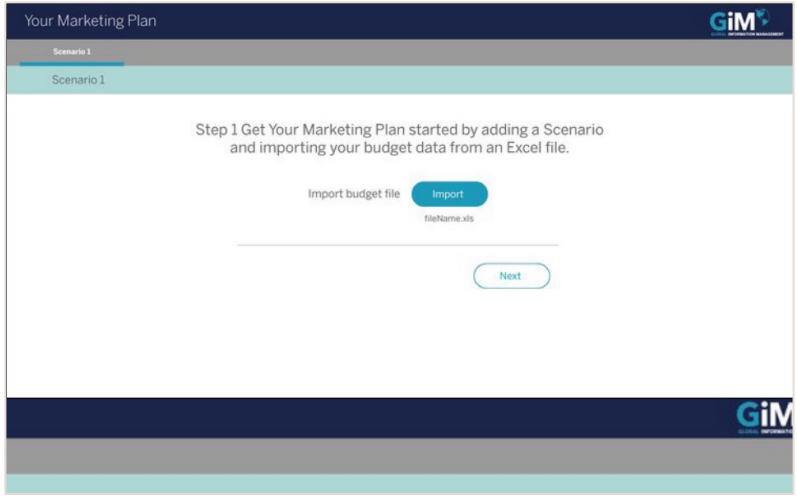
Guide the first visit with a wizard

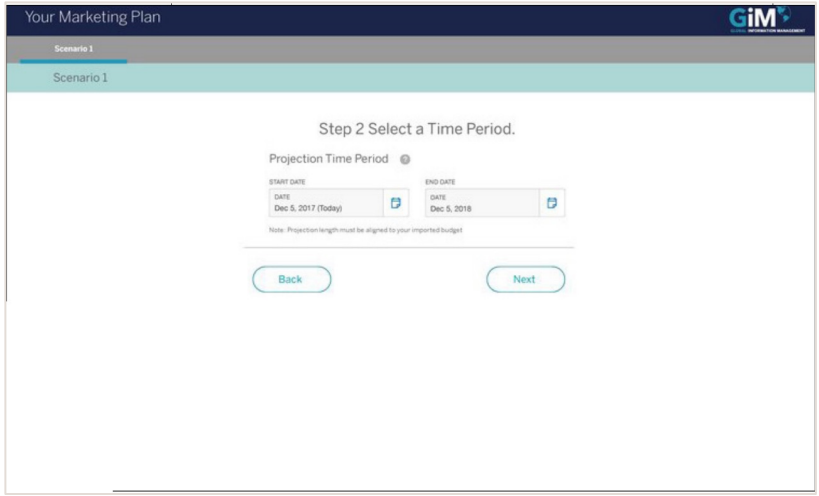
Why

Partners plan only every 6–12 months, so each visit feels like the first. A short wizard sets the essentials: import last year's budget from Excel, then pick the time period.

Trade-off

A few extra steps for the rare expert who knows the tool. We kept them short and skippable once data is imported. (confirm)





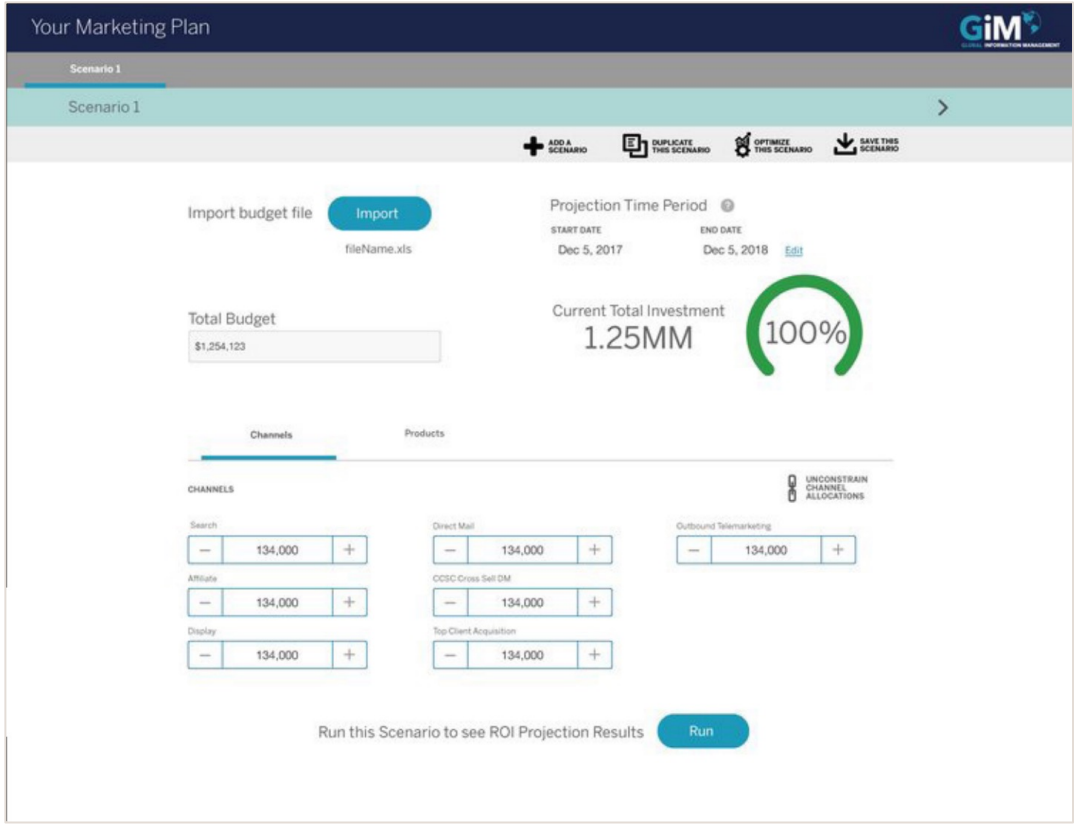
Build the plan down to channel and product

Why

Partners asked to “build a plan down to the product line and channel”. Each allocation is adjustable, starting from an imported budget kept as a template, so a second plan starts from the first.

Trade-off

More controls on one screen. Channels and products sit on separate tabs, and a running total shows how much is left to allocate.



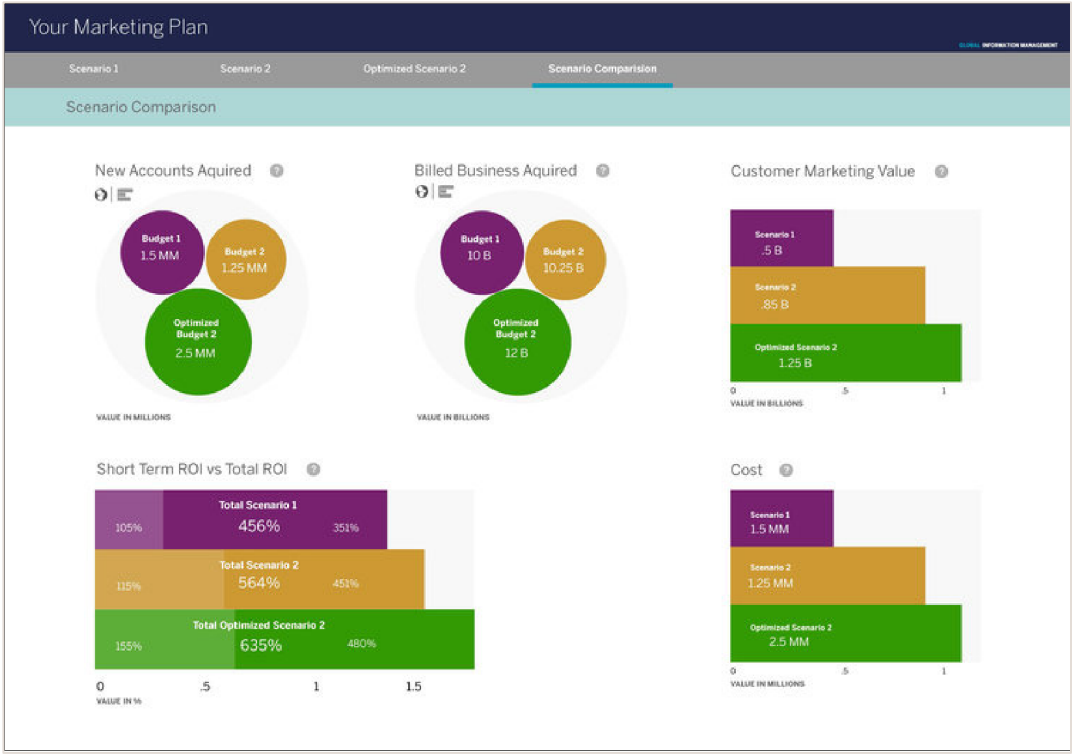
Compare scenarios; the partner chooses

Why

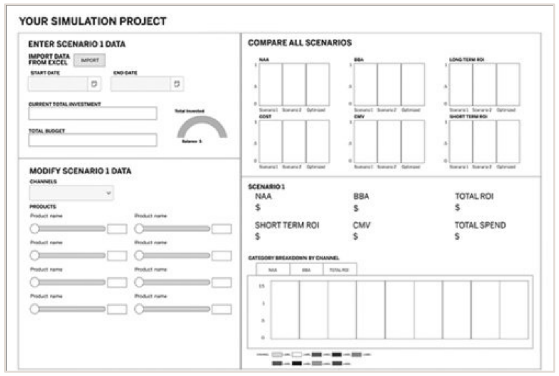
Confidence came from comparison. Scenarios sit side by side with an optimized plan from the data scientists' engine, shown with the metrics partners care about: accounts, billed business, ROI, cost.

Trade-off

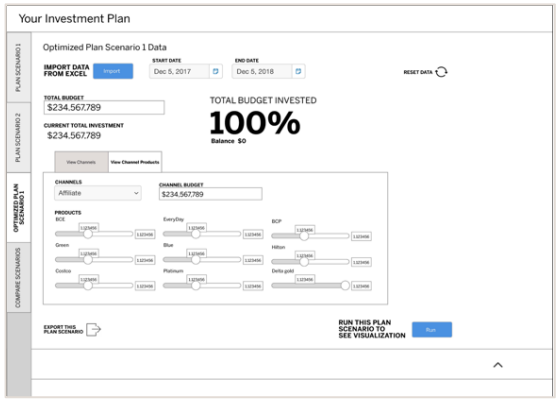
The optimizer proposes; it does not decide. The partner picks the plan and can see why the optimized one differs, so trust stays with them.



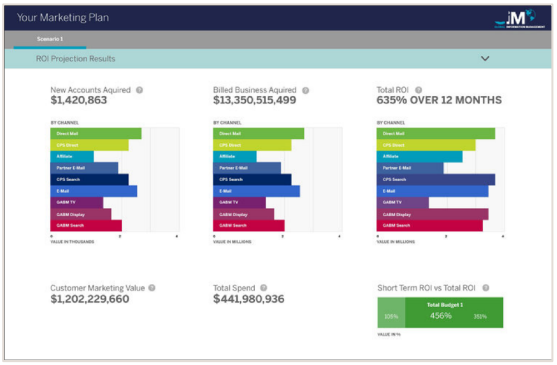
From sketch to shipped, and what testing changed



Sketch



Mid-fidelity



Final: ROI projection

What testing changed

Duplicate an imported budget as a template: users wanted to start plan two from plan one

Reset became its own tool, after users kept looking for it

The navigation bar with a toolbar scored high and stayed

Short term vs long term became a first-class view

Exporting, duplicating and saving moved up: partners called them vital

Toggling chart types stayed; channel breakdown was called “a game changer”

Leading from the work

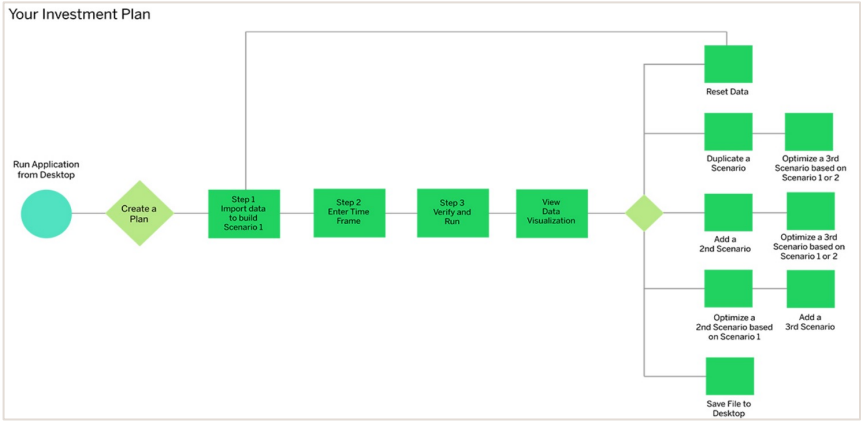
My role

Owned discovery, research and UX strategy

Designed the flows and screens myself, from sketches to final

Ran Lean UX and usability testing on a regular cadence

Presented the work to the client and key stakeholders



Working with data scientists

Co-designed with the data scientists who built the projection and optimization engines, so the interface showed what the models could support and nothing more.

Delivery

12 Agile sprints · usability testing every cycle · demos and QA

What I'd do differently today

The fundamentals held up. With today's tools I would change the level, not the goal.

Explain the optimizer, line by line

Show why the optimized plan moves money between channels, in the partner's terms, so trust comes from understanding.

Prototype the engine early, in code

Test real projections with partners in week one, instead of after the model was built.

Measure trust, not just completion

Track how often partners pick the optimized plan and why they change it, as a guardrail on the model.

If we can measure it, we can manage it. MOCA set its baseline in discovery and reported against it after launch: the habit I bring to every project.

Michael Thibodeau

I design AI people can trust with their money, and I lead teams that build it fast.

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